

The Blueprint

RESTAURANT - NIGHT. An after-work crowd unwinds in dim, lively comfort that is filled with laughter. It's just a normal Friday night with my friends after a very long week of work. It feels like everyone in this restaurant is at the point in their life where they just slip into the safety of a routine, with only the occasional night out to hide the burnout from their life.

Me, Sam, Violet, Anna, and Mark sit together at a table. The air is thick with laughter. And right on queue, when all the stories about their weeks are gone, everyone starts talking about the idea of love and their love life.

LEO

Honestly? I think the whole "materialistic" label is a bit of a cop-out. It's not a gender thing. We're all looking for security, for status.

SAM

Oh yeah, then why do girls get such a bad rap for it, like on Instagram or TikTok?

MARK

Maybe it is more common for girls to do it? Like, men are simple creatures. We do dumb sh*t all the time without complaining.

ANNA

Wait what! Don't act like you have no standards when it comes to dating. Have you seen your lists of demands before you met me?

Anna shifts away from Mark, nudging his arm off her as she puts space between them.

LEO

Okay, okay, calm down... I think it is like this because it's new. I am no feminist, but

historically, men were allowed to make demands, and women were expected to adjust. That dynamic was treated as normal for a long time. Now that we are beyond that, a lot of guys still compare it to the old days and just point it out as demanding.

VIOLET

Makes sense, kinda like that perfect body, ages, and salary thing. I think it is fair. When you are new, you don't want what you want, so you draw a list of a perfect someone. Everyone has one.

LEO

Exactly. But when you meet that person, the one who clicks, the list is gone. And that is when you know you have found the one.

MARK

(Chuckled)

It sort of like being picky and materialistic is a shield that you unconsciously put on yourself until you meet that person.

VIOLET

So... have you met her, Leo? The one who made you drop the list?

Leo looks across the table at Violet, who is listening intently. His eyes give away everything he cannot say. Violet felt a sharp, unexpected jolt and quickly looked down at the ice in her lemonade, afraid her surprise was visible. He wants to say something, but he just shakes it off and looks down at his half-eaten burgers.

LEO

I don't know. I haven't dated anyone yet. Maybe not yet..

Mark then punches Leo's shoulders and laughs.

MARK

Said the guy who said all of these things.

LEO

Yeah, I have a lot of references.

ANNA

Like what? Mark and I together?

LEO

Well, I mean, yeah. I have great models of what real love looks like. Growing up, I saw it constantly from my mom and dad, my uncle, and my aunt.

VIOLET

Still have no idea what you mean?

Violet takes a sip of her iced lemonade. An iced tea in an upscale restaurant instead of the classic cocktail, like Anna. Not something bold like a beer, like Mark over here. Not a Diet Coke like the quiet Sam, who is sitting on the sideline, enjoying his tacos while everyone is discussing. Weird pick for a night out with friends who are just letting loose and rewarding them with something nice after a week.

Similar to Leo right here, who just wants to drink water, claiming that it is the only refreshing drink and that feels like a b.s reason. But both of them go to the gym often, so who knows. Maybe there is a beauty to just drinking something healthy for you.

LEO

Well, you all know that my uncle stayed with my Aunt for 10 years until she passed away from cancer. Doing everything to give his family the best life, both financially and stuff.

SAM

Yeah, how is he right now? And can I have some of your fries?

Leo just pushed his French fries dish toward Sam.

LEO

Just take them. He is fine, by the way. And my dad, who decided not to go study abroad, stayed with my mom.

ANNA

About that, did you ever ask your dad about why he didn't go rather than just staying with your mom? Like, people had phones back then, you know.

MARK

Yeah, I also wondered that. What life could have been if you knew you were a U.S citizen instead of having to try to get PR? Would we even have met each other?

LEO

I don't know. But I did ask my dad last Sunday, though.

VIOLET

Seriously, what did he say?

LEO

Well, he simply doesn't really value being rich and successful that much. We already live comfortably, so being rich is just an extra thing we can do, not mandatory. Plus, my mom was carrying my sister back then, so if he left, she would have to take care of her alone for four years. He said his family needed him more than his career at that time.

MARK

Fair point!

Leo took a sip of his now cool drink and said.

LEO

Pretty sure if he left for the U.S., there is no way I would come to exist since I am four years older than my sister.

SAM

Now that answers your question, Mark. We would not meet each other.

Leo bursts into laughter with Mark, while Anna just rolls her eyes, staring at the similarly annoyed Violet.

LEO

Yeah, and he bought an interesting conversation. Why do you guys want to be rich?

SAM

To buy cool sh*t that normal people can't afford.

MARK

Right, and that is what is important, huh? Have you even listened to Leo's dad? I want to be rich to try new stuff with my bae.

He slips an arm around her, pulling her close, giving her a soft shake. Anna is visible brushing. Loving couples, am I right, they can go from hating each other to loving each other in just one second.

LEO

Happy wife, happy life...

VIOLET

Experience is a good answer, though. I think having an option to just try is the goal. Like, we are still in our 20s. There are more things to explore.

LEO

I am with you guys, especially. I swear, if I had someone, I would spoil her so much.

SAM

We know, dude. The guy who will always do the cooking and the dish every day. And, giving her everything.

LEO

There is beauty to it. You will see what you mean.

After taking a bite from his pasta dish, Mark looks at Leo and raises his beer slightly, almost like a toast to no one, and drinks.

MARK

Leo, you are the cutest guy that I know.

LEO

I swear, what the f*ck.

Violet is surprised by the reaction. Even though she has many male friends and understands the typical banter, teasing, and rage baiting, the exchange seems strange to her, as it does to everyone else.

VIOLET

What?

LEO

Why do I only hear those compliments from guys and not girls? Like, am I just that unlucky in relationships?

SAM

I don't know. Sounds like you are very popular with guys.

MARK

Yeah, that is a very great observation actually. Why don't you try the other gender? Expand your search.

LEO

Bro, I am not gay.

Mark and Sam erupt into uncontrollable laughter, as if they have been bottling up every last bit of lightness all week just for this moment. The girls seem to just enjoy the moment as well, but not to the point of the two guys.

Maybe moments like this are why everyone endures their life. Little moments that always seem to brighten the week. Maybe the good times are always more memorable than the bad times, and everyone instinctively knows it. And maybe next time Leo will not be sacrificed for the laughter of everyone, and that is what everyone calls even.

And maybe that is the beauty of life, you win some, you lose some, but you always seem to only remember the time you win more.

OUTSIDE RESTAURANT - NIGHT. They finish their meals, and the laughter and conversation slowly fade as they settle the bill. The friends step out into the cool night air. Sam, Anna, and Mark drift off, climbing into an Uber or walking back to their small apartments. Leo and Violet stand a little apart, closer to the curb, where Leo checks his phone for their ride.

LEO

Looks like my Uber is still two minutes out.

Violet, at that moment, shivers slightly, pulling her cardigan tighter.

VIOLET

Mine is like ten.

Leo chuckles, putting his phone away. He turns to face her fully.

LEO

Hey. I just wanted to say... thanks.

VIOLET

For what? For being a great friend? You're welcome.

LEO

No, ha ha. I mean for this. For introducing me to them. To Sam, Mark, and Anna, a while ago. I know I was new to the city, and you didn't have to bring me into your circle. It's been... nice, honestly.

VIOLET

We needed you, Leo. Someone to call out Mark's sh*t, and another person to share Sam's fries with. Besides, you're fun.

LEO

I appreciate it. It means a lot.

The lights of an approaching car sweep across the street. Leo, check the license plate. The Uber driver brings his window down.

UBER DRIVER

Is this Leo?

LEO

Yeah, that's me.

Leo turns back to Violet. Noticing she is still shivering, he quickly unzips his black washed hoodie and hands it to her.

LEO

Here. Put this on. It's colder than I thought. And I am heading home now, so just take it.

Violet hesitates for a second, looking at the hoodie.

LEO

Take it. But remember to give it back. Seriously, this is my favorite hoodie.

Violet smiles, pulling the oversized hoodie on.

VIOLET

Thanks, Leo. Get home safe. See you next week or something soon.

Leo waves a final goodbye and climbs into the back seat. As the car pulls away, she watches the taillights disappear into the city traffic, standing alone under the streetlights, wrapped in the warmth of the hoodie.

Maybe a life is actually that simple. We overcomplicate the search for a perfect, successful existence, but perhaps all we truly need are these brief breaks from the routine. There is no need for a perfect Hollywood successful lifestyle. Perhaps the blueprint for a good life was never about chasing success, but just about collecting these small, unscripted moments that make everything else worth enduring.